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An Identification and Examination of Influences That Shape the Creation of a Professional Team Fan

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An Identification and Examination of Influences That Shape the Creation of a Professional Team Fan

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Executive Summary

Sport organizations recognize the importance of a strong fan base, yet little research has been done to help organizations understand how to build and maintain such a group of fans. There is ample evidence that people are readily able to form deep attachments to sports teams. A body of research has examined the level of attachment (i.e. identification) that fans have with a team (Branscombe and Wann, 1991; Wann and Branscombe, 1993, 1995; Wann and Dolan, 1994), and also the relationship between level of identification with a team and different types of fan responses. Fans' emotions, perceptions of influence on team performance and game outcomes, objective knowledge and subjective beliefs about their team, and enjoyment of sports events have all been related to identification levels among United States collegiate sport fans (e.g. Murrell and Dietz, 1992; Wann and Branscombe, 1995; Wann, Dolan, McGeorge and Allison, 1994).

The small amount of work that has been done on building and maintaining a fan base has focused primarily on maintenance issues. Sutton, McDonald, Milne and Cimperman (1997) suggested that a sport franchise could foster fan relationships by having a successful team and a good organizational reputation, creating some connection with the community, and by providing as many consumption opportunities as possible for people. Mahony,

Madrigal and Howard (1999) found that loyalty to professional teams in the National Football League (NFL) in the United States could be largely determined by knowing a fan's specific personality characteristic. To date, however, research has not adequately examined what factors incipiently influence a person to become a team fan. Knowing what influences people to become team fans is important because these factors are the corner stones for creating, building, and maintaining a base of loyal team fans.

The current study was designed to explore and identify: (1) when in their life span individuals became team fans; and (2) what people and things affect this process. A survey was conducted with long-term season ticket holders ($N = 518$) of a professional National Football League (NFL) team in the United States to address these issues.

The results suggested that fathers were very influential in shaping team preferences, particularly among those who became fans in their preteen years and, to a somewhat lesser extent, among adolescents. The majority of respondents stated that they had become a team fan prior to age 15. Players and coaches of the team were important influences for those who became fans as adolescents or adults. The emotional hometown connection fans made between the city in which the team plays and the team itself was influential in shaping team loyalty. Attending and experiencing the excitement of games was also a catalyst for becoming a team fan. Respondents valued being part



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of a “community” of fans (i.e. a group of people sharing a common bond – the team).

Sports marketers who wish to build the next generation of fans need to create opportunities for fathers to spend time with their children at team-related activities. Developing and promoting linkages between a team and the city in which the team is located has value in building team loyalty as well. Such linkages help fans attribute positive characteristics to both the team and city, thereby reinforcing strong feelings held about each entity. The community of fans concept can be used to build linkages to the teams. One means for creating esprit de corps among fans is to use e-mail and other team-sponsored Internet forums to encourage fans to discuss among themselves their feelings about the team. Team personnel can monitor this information to identify trends and other issues important to team fans.

An Identification and Examination of Influences That Shape the Creation of a Professional Team Fan

While we often speak of the interest in sports among the collective population, it is the individual fan who invests her/his time, money and self in sports. One question raised by the prevalence of sports in society is how this fascination with sports develops at the individual level. Of particular interest in the current study is the issue of who and/or what influences people to form attachments to a sports team. What is especially interesting about this issue is that, for many, these are not casual relationships with their chosen team, but rather relationships that are temporally persistent and very resistant to change. The complexity of this phenomenon is manifest by fans who remain strongly attached to their chosen team, even when the team performs poorly for periods of time (e.g. the Chicago Cubs baseball team in the US and Manchester City Football Club in the UK).

A relatively small body of research has provided some understanding about the appeal of sport. Research has distinguished between spectators (those who merely observe sport)

and fans (those who are allegiant to specific sports or teams) (Pooley, 1978). Others have demonstrated that people have different levels of identification (psychological attachment) with sports teams (Branscombe and Wann, 1991; Murrell and Dietz, 1992; Trail and James, 1999; Wann and Branscombe, 1993, 1995; Wann and Dolan, 1994; Wann, Dolan, McGeorge and Allison, 1994). Research has also tried to profile committed sports fans (Smith, Patterson, Williams and Hogg, 1981); to demonstrate basking-in-reflected-glory (raising one's self-esteem by associating with a source – a winning team); to demonstrate cutting-off-reflected-failure (distancing oneself from an unattractive source – a losing team) (Cialdini, Borden, Thorne, Walker, Freeman and Sloan, 1976; Snyder, Lassegard and Ford, 1986); and to identify motives of sport fans (Milne and McDonald, 1999; Sloan, 1989; Trail and James, 1999; Wann, 1995). However, research has not adequately examined what influences a person to become a fan of a particular sport or team and to form a persistent attachment with a sport/team.

This issue is important to understand from a practical perspective due to the increased competition for the hearts and wallets of fans. By studying the dimensions that influence an individual to form a relationship with a specific team, the opportunity exists not only to know how to facilitate the development of new fans, but also to strengthen relationships with existing fans. The purpose of the present study is to advance the field's understanding of sport fans by identifying and examining the dimensions that initially influence people to become fans of a particular team.

Background

Most attempts to understand a fan's relationship with a team have focused on what a sport organization can do to promote or maintain relationships with existing fans. For example, Sutton, McDonald, Milne and Cimperman (1997) proposed that identification (attachment) with a sport team could be explained based on an individual's level of satisfaction,

the reputation of a sport organization, the fan's frequency of contact with the team, and his/her visibility of affiliation with an organization. Mahony, Madrigal and Howard (1999) argue that a person's willingness to continue as a team fan is related to his/her level of self-monitoring (the willingness/ability to change one's image in the face of situational change). Mahony *et al.* (1999) argue that an individual's degree of self-monitoring is inversely related to team loyalty (e.g. high self-monitors are not likely to be loyal fans). The implications of these studies are very useful for maintaining a fan base, but do not shed light on what initial influences someone to become a team fan.

Wann, Tucker and Schrader (1996) conducted an exploratory examination of why people begin, continue and end their identification (or attachment) with sports teams. Three commonly-found influences listed for the three phases of identification (begin, continue, end) were: (1) success of the team; (2) geographical location; and (3) the fact that friends/peers followed a team. The findings of Wann *et al.* (1996) do not provide a full explanation of what influences an individual to become a fan of a specific team, but they do suggest some factors that warrant further examination.

James (1997) looked at some of the ideas associated with becoming a fan by examining when children are chronologically/cognitively capable of demonstrating a psychological commitment to a sport or team that is resistant to change (i.e. fan loyalty). The study, conducted with two groups of children (five to six and eight to nine years of age), focused on identifying when a child first demonstrates the characteristics of a fan, and also identified what factors influenced children to form an initial preference for, and attachment to, a particular sport or team. Findings indicated that children must reach a minimum level of cognitive development, which usually occurs around age seven, in order to form an enduring commitment to a specific team. James (1997) also reported that preferences for a specific sport or team were influenced by several factors, including family members (particularly fathers), personal partic-

ipation in sports, and television.

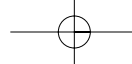
There are other potential influences on fans as well. For example, having a link to a city where one has opportunities to watch, read about and follow a team may well be important in influencing which team a person may support. Combining this idea with the findings reported by James (1997) suggests that becoming a team fan is influenced by both personal and social-situational factors.

Socialization Theory

The influence of personal and social-situational dimensions on becoming a team fan may be partially explained via socialization theory. Socialization involves the assimilation and development of skills, knowledge, values, dispositions and self-perceptions necessary to perform in society (Kenyon and McPherson, 1973). Socialization is a process by which individuals not only learn social mores but also come to accept and endorse these socially-advocated values and behaviors, experiencing them as their own. Thus, for socialization to truly occur, the individual needs to carry out these values and behaviors volitionally, thereby taking personal ownership of them (Grolnick, Deci and Ryan, 1997).

In the context of being a team fan, socialization involves learning and internalizing the attitudes, values, knowledge and behaviors that are associated with fans of a team. This process results in individual-level internalizations and an appreciation of the importance of being a fan of the team. Socialization theory would suggest that an individual's personal characteristics, significant others, and social settings contribute both independently, and in combination, to the development of knowledge, values, dispositions and self-perceptions requisite to being a team fan. These ideas indicate that becoming a fan involves more than merely focusing on team-related factors, but necessitates that some consideration be given to the effects of interpersonal factors and social environments on team loyalty.

Socialization issues in the context of sport fans have not been given much attention.



Creation of a Professional Team Fan

However, the research examining the process of an individual's socialization into sport is clearly germane to the current study because it looks at how different socializing agents influence an individual to participate in sports (Kenyon, 1970; Sage, 1974; Snyder and Spreitzer, 1974; Spreitzer and Snyder, 1976). Studies in this area have shown that interest in a particular sport can be influenced by family, peers, teachers and coaches (Kenyon, 1968; Kenyon and McPherson, 1973; Malumphy, 1970; McPherson, 1976; Sage, 1974; Snyder and Spreitzer, 1974; Spreitzer and Snyder, 1976).

Drawing from the findings of the socialization-into-sport research, it can be argued that becoming a team fan begins with an introduction to sports and to a specific team in a sport. The introduction process likely occurs for many fans early in life through their family. Peer influence may also contribute to an individual's early socialization experience relative to sports (e.g. playing with friends, talking about sports with peers, participating in youth leagues etc.). The mass media has an important and influential role in sport socialization by providing opportunities for an individual to become acquainted with teams and players on specific teams.

After an individual is introduced to a specific team, the interaction between the individual and significant others provides the cues or feedback from which an individual develops the knowledge, values and dispositions of a team fan to form a commitment to that team. One additional dimension to consider is that various socializing agents may have a differential influence over individuals at certain points in their life and in certain life situations. For example, young children may be influenced most by their families and personal experiences. For adults, peers, community associations or some other dimension (or a combination of dimensions) may be most influential in shaping team loyalty. This suggests that becoming a fan, and remaining a fan, of a specific team may be viewed along a continuum. As an individual forms a commitment to a specific team, that commitment may be

affected by different socializing agents at different points on the continuum. The current study focuses on identifying the dimensions that influence an individual's initial decision to become a team fan.

Research Questions

Given the limited amount of research pertaining to the process of team fan creation, the current study was intentionally exploratory in nature. Because research has not isolated the dimensions that influence an individual to become a team fan, the goal of the research was to identify influences that were involved in the socialization of individuals as fans of a professional sports team. In order to provide direction for the study, two general research questions were established.

1. Which people and things most strongly influence an individual's decision to become a team fan?

The study used respondents' self reports and ratings of various socialization agents as the basis for identifying major and minor sources of influence.

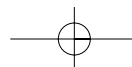
It is also useful to ascertain whether an individual recognizes when (or if) they made a conscious decision to follow a specific team (i.e. feel an attachment to a specific team). It is expected that an individual with a strong attachment to a specific team would be able to know approximately when s/he became a team fan. Further, we sought to determine whether attachment is most likely to occur first in youth, and if so, when in the developmental years do attachments typically form? Thus, research question two states:

2. In what age period does an individual typically become a team fan?

Method

Sample

A mail survey was sent to Personal Seat License (PSL)/Season ticket holders of the Cleveland Browns football team. The Browns



organization was a National Football League (USA) trusteeship at the time of the survey as the team was “officially” on hiatus from the NFL during the 1996 through 1998 football seasons. The Browns Trust sold PSLs during 1997 and 1998 to past season ticket holders in anticipation of a new Browns team in 1999. (A personal seat license is purchased so that the holder has the right to buy season tickets in a specific stadium seat location. Team owners sell PSLs in order to obtain additional funds. In this case, these funds were used to defer new stadium construction costs.)

Sampling season ticket holders provided an opportunity to study individuals who had a breadth of experience with the team. This group contained those who had attended games as season ticket holders for only a few years, while others had been ticket holders for over 40 years. These individuals had also purchased PSLs knowing they would have to wait two years before a new Cleveland Browns team would play. Thus, the longevity of their relationship and breadth of experiences with the team, coupled with their financial commitment to the Browns, made them an interesting subject pool for studying issues of team loyalty and loyalty development.

A stratified sample of respondents was drawn from the pool of season ticket accounts. Four strata were used to draw a representative sample of season ticket holders:

- (1) season ticket holders of 10 years or less;
- (2) season ticket holders from 11 to 20 years;
- (3) season ticket holders of more than 20 years;
- and (4) “Dawg Pound” season ticket holders. (The Dawg Pound section of Cleveland Municipal Stadium was where boisterous and raucous fans tended to sit.)

By sampling proportionately within the strata, the final sample was expected to parallel the composition of the season ticket holder popu-

lation, which, in actuality, held true in the sample of respondents.

The survey instrument was mailed by the Browns organization to 2,000 season ticket holders together with a cover letter. Five hundred and eighteen useable questionnaires were returned by the cut-off date, yielding a response rate of 25.9%.

Survey Instrument

The questionnaire was eight pages in length and consisted of a combination of scaled questions and open-ended items. A portion of the scaled items and one of the open-ended items are reported here. Individual items were distributed throughout the survey instrument to reduce order and other biases. Respondents tended to be very thorough in completing the questionnaire and often provided side comments and supplemental information about the issues addressed in the survey, suggesting the strength of their interest in the topic matter.

Areas addressed in the questionnaire were identified by background interviewing and focus group sessions conducted with Browns season ticket holders. Specific survey items were derived from the information collected in these preliminary studies.

An open-ended question allowed those completing the survey to identify the one person who had the most influence on them becoming a Browns fan. Another series of scaled questions measured how much influence various team-related activities had on the respondent becoming a Browns fan. Questions were asked as to how important it was to be a fan of the home team and to belong to the group of Browns fans. Respondents were also asked to indicate at what age they felt they became a Cleveland Browns fan.

Data Analysis

Means and standard deviations were calculated for all the scaled items. The sample was divided into three groups based on the age at which respondents reported becoming a team fan. This allowed the analysis of group differences via chi-square. Chi-square analysis was

Table 1: Person who had the Greatest Impact on Respondent Becoming a Browns Fan

Person Having Most Impact	Frequency	Percentage
Relatives		
Father	193	38.8
Brother	16	3.2
Wife	13	2.6
Husband	10	2.0
Mother	8	1.6
Uncle	8	1.6
Both Parents	5	1.0
Son	3	0.6
Other Relatives (In-laws, Cousins, etc.)	17	3.4
Browns Players and Coaches		
Specific Players	89	17.9
Specific Coaches	34	6.8
Radio Announcers	2	0.4
Other Individuals		
Myself	39	7.8
Friends	27	5.4
Other	34	6.8

used to examine differences in the group distributions on the items pertaining to who had the greatest impact on the respondent becoming a team fan.

Results

The respondents were primarily males (86.7%) between the ages of 36 and 55 (65.4%; modal age category was 41 to 45 years old). Most respondents were married (79.3%). The average respondent had been a fan of the team for over 30 years and a season ticket holder for 21 years.

Influential People in Becoming a Fan

Respondents were first asked to indicate, in a free-response question, the one person who was most influential to them in becoming a team fan. The results support the expectation that family members would be influential, as

38.8% of respondents reported "father" as the one person who had the greatest impact on them becoming a team fan (see Table 1). Specific players were also identified as influence agents; however, the most frequently reported players were those who played on the team during the 1950s and 1960s. Given the average age of the respondents and the age at which many of them became fans of the team (discussed later), this finding is not surprising. Perhaps most interesting of these data was that 39 (7.8%) respondents said that they themselves, and not another person, were the reason why they became Browns fans.

Events and Their Influence on Becoming a Fan

The non-person fan influence dimensions are grouped in Table 2 by content. These items were rated on the seven-point influence scale.

Table 2: Influences on Becoming a Browns Fan

Category and Item	Mean	Standard Deviation
Social/Community Issues		
Growing up in Cleveland (n = 372)	6.19	1.38
The Browns as my hometown team (n = 470)	6.17	1.33
The Browns as a Cleveland Institution (n = 504)	5.99	1.36
Game Attendance and Atmosphere Dimensions		
The game-day atmosphere in Municipal Stadium (n = 504)	6.05	1.32
The experience of attending games at the stadium (n = 500)	5.86	1.49
Attending my first game at Municipal Stadium (n = 493)	5.06	1.87
Tailgating experiences before Browns games (n = 364)	3.82	2.16
Tradition of the Team		
The Browns team history (n = 503)	5.69	1.48
The Browns as an "in your face, in the mud" kind of football team (n = 499)	5.08	1.77
Team Experience Associated with Family		
Watching the Browns on TV with my family (n = 493)	5.73	1.34
Family traditions associated with the Browns (n = 439)	4.70	1.97
Non-Game Activities		
Meeting Browns players as an adult (n = 386)	5.57	1.97
Meeting Browns players as a child (n = 282)	3.97	2.12
Visiting the Browns training camp (n = 323)	3.92	2.00
Becoming a member of a Browns Backers group (n = 218)	2.76	1.92

Note. Means were obtained from a seven-point scale anchored by 1 (Extremely Influential) and 7 (Not at all Influential). The scale was reverse-scored for data analysis purposes so that high numbers would represent positive scores. Respondents also had the option of 9, "Doesn't Apply to me." These responses were not included in the data used to calculate means and standard deviations.

Factors that were rated as having strong influences on the fans included "growing up in Cleveland" (M = 6.19), "the Browns as my hometown team" (M = 6.17), "the Browns as a Cleveland Institution" (M = 5.99), and "the game-day atmosphere in Municipal Stadium" (M = 6.05; see Table 2).

It is interesting to note that among these four items, only one deals directly with experiences with the team. The others are associations made between the team and the municipality of Cleveland. A second level of factors includes attending games at the stadium (par-

ticularly attending their first game), team history, and watching the team on TV with family members (see Table 2). These items were given moderately high ratings. Activities related to the team, such as pre-game tailgating (partying in the parking lot before games), meeting players, visiting training camp, and team style are less important than the city/team association (see Table 2). The latter issues may be things that fans do, but they appear not to be major influences on why they became fans of the team.

Table 3: "Community" Issues with Team

Item	Mean	Standard Deviation
Home-town Team Issues		
It is very important to me that the Browns are my home-town team (n = 502)	5.66	1.59
The Browns have the same qualities as the City of Cleveland (n = 505)	4.47	1.80
If you are born in Cleveland, you have to be a Browns fan (n = 508)	4.47	2.08
You have to be from Cleveland to be a Cleveland Browns fan (n = 507)	1.97	1.54
Membership in the Community of Browns Fans		
I value the fact that there are Browns fans all around the world (n = 510)	5.78	1.50
I like the idea that I am part of a "community of Browns fans" (n = 508)	5.64	1.39
I feel a connective bond with other Browns fans (n = 509)	5.35	1.57

Note. Items rated on 7-point scale anchored by Strongly Disagree (1) and Strongly Agree (7).

Importance of City and Community of Fans

Two general issues were examined pertaining to the concept of "community" for sport fans. The topic examined here is the issue of the Browns as the fan's hometown team. A second dimension of "community" is the idea of a community of fans. A community of fans contains individuals for whom the Browns are their hometown team, but also includes those fans who live outside of the city. For example, there are extensive numbers of formal and informal "Browns Backers" groups located across the United States and around the world. Most Browns fans know of the existence of these fan groups and their activities pertaining to the team.

The results suggest a strong importance given to the association between the city and the team in regard to the Browns being the fan's hometown team. As shown in Table 3, the fans, on average, agreed with the statement that it was important to them that the Browns

were their hometown team ($M = 5.66$). Approximately two-thirds of respondents (65.1%) rated this item as a 6 or 7 on the 7-point Likert-type scale. Respondents did not link the qualities of Cleveland with the team, nor did they feel that being born in Cleveland requires one to become a Browns fan, nor is being a Cleveland native a mandatory requirement for becoming a fan (see Table 3). This is an interesting set of findings because these fans are not expressing a narrow tolerance level or standards for membership in the "community" of Browns fans. Instead, the fans are expressing almost universal openness to membership in this team-related social group.

Respondents generally felt positively toward the idea of a community of Browns fans outside of Cleveland and liked the idea that they were a part of this community. Respondents also gave a relatively high rating to the idea of being connected to other Browns fans (see Table 3).

Table 4: Respondent's Age When S/he Became a "True" Browns Fan

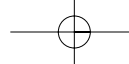
Age Range	Frequency	Percentage
0 to 5 Years Old	17	3.3
6 to 10 Years Old	172	33.2
11 to 15 Years Old	100	19.3
16 to 20 Years Old	81	15.6
21 to 25 Years Old	48	9.3
26 to 30 Years Old	38	7.3
31 to 35 Years Old	19	3.7
36 to 40 Years Old	14	2.7
41 to 55 Years Old	11	2.1
Not Applicable	2	0.4
No Response	16	3.1
Total	518	100%

Note. Respondents' open-ended responses to this item were grouped into the categories presented in this table for expository purposes.

Table 5: Crosstabulation of Age When Respondent Became a Browns Fan by Person Who Had Greatest Impact on Respondent Becoming a Browns Fan

Person Who Had Greatest Impact on Respondent Becoming a Browns Fan	Age When Became a Browns Fan			Row Totals
	12 Years and Under	13 to 20 Years Old	21 Years and Older	
Father	126 57.8	52 40.0	12 10.1	190
Family Members	28 12.8	16 12.3	31 26.1	75
Browns Players or Coaches	45 20.6	37 28.5	38 31.9	120
Other	16 7.3	14 10.8	30 25.2	60
Friends	3 1.4	11 8.5	8 6.7	22
Column Totals	218	130	119	467

Note. Chi-Square = 87.18, df = 8, $p < .001$. The top number in the body of the table represents the frequency count. Below the frequency count is the percentage of the column total represented by the frequency.



Creation of a Professional Team Fan

Age When Became a True Fan

The respondents were asked to provide a specific numerical answer to the question: "At what age do you feel you became a true Cleveland Browns fan?" No response categories were provided, nor was "true fan" defined for the respondents. The responses were grouped into the age increments, as presented in Table 4, for expository purposes. Though not shown in the categorized data presented in Table 4, analysis of the uncategorized data found that the modal age at which people felt they became team fans was ten years old (16.7%). Approximately 56% of the respondents indicated that they had become true fans of the team prior to age 15 (see Table 4), with most of these respondents indicating that they had become true fans between six and 15 years of age.

The respondents were regrouped into three age-range categories (based on when they became true fans of the team). The age categories address the age groups of childhood/preteen (0 to 12 years old), adolescence (13 to 20 years old), and adulthood (21 years and older). The goal was to ascertain whether there were differential influences on individuals becoming team fans given different ages at which they became fans.

Significant differences ($p < .001$) were found, via chi-square analysis, in the distribution of influence agents for each age group (see Table 5). (The responses to the influence agent item, fully enumerated in Table 1, were collapsed into five categories for analysis purposes in Table 5.) Fathers (57.8%) and players/coaches (20.6%) were the "greatest impact" people for those who became team fans as preteens. This pattern was similar for those in the adolescent fan group, although father was not as strong as among preteens (see Table 5). Among those who became fans as adults, players/coaches had the most impact, followed by family members, and assorted others (including self).

Discussion

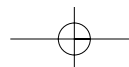
An individual likely does not become a fan of a specific team on a whim. Socialization the-

ory would suggest that someone becomes a fan of a sports team as a result of the separate and combined influences of an individual's personal characteristics, significant others and social settings.

The first research question sought to identify what people and things were influential in shaping an individual's decision to become a team fan. The findings demonstrated that several factors had influenced respondents to become team fans, with the most prominent being "fathers". In addition, findings related to the second research question demonstrated that various factors exert a differential influence, depending upon the age at which an individual acknowledges becoming a team fan.

For individuals who became a team fan early in life (preteen), fathers had the most influence. For individuals who formed a commitment to the team during adolescence (13 to 20 years), several factors seem to exert an influence. Fathers were found to influence and have an impact on an individual becoming a fan, but to a lesser extent than among those in the preteen group. Fathers clearly have a role in creating loyalty to a team, but during adolescence, players or coaches served as influence agents for creating fan loyalty as well. Issues of modeling (emulating specific athletes) and/or one's ability to comprehend a sport as played by professional athletes may be necessary before someone is influenced by players; hence, players and coaches are more likely to be comparatively more influential among older groups of fans than younger fans.

For individuals who reported that they became a Browns fan as an adult (21 years or older), there was a distinct difference in the factors that influenced their decision. Players and coaches were most frequently found to have an influence on a person forming an attachment with the Browns. In general, adults may approach the game and its participants differently than younger fans and subsequently draw attachments to a team in a different manner. Though not among the most frequently reported single influence agents for this group, respondents in the adolescent and



adult fan groups did rate friends as influential in the process of becoming a team fan. Overall, it would seem that different influence agents are operating here and that the nature of the influence may be different than among those who became fans at a younger age.

The results showed that most respondents became fans of the team after they were about six years old. This finding coincides with James' (1997) conclusion that individuals may need to acquire certain cognitive abilities before they can become true fans and that such development occurs typically at age seven. It might be argued that it is difficult for people to specify exactly when they became a team fan (though some fans were very exact in their dating of this event). However, the preponderance of the six- to 15-year-old age range suggests that respondents are pointing to their early childhood years as the point where the onset of their team relationship occurred. The six to 15 age range may be a significant period for the formation of relationships with social entities such as sports teams. In practical terms, this finding would argue that sports marketers should focus their efforts on attracting individuals in this age group, in order to establish a cadre of loyal fans for the future. Sports marketers may also give attention to those younger than six in order to "plant the seeds" of team loyalty with these children as they grow towards having sufficient levels of cognitive maturity.

The study identified factors that may reinforce an individual's relationship with his/her team. Team-related activities, such as pre-game tailgating, meeting players and visiting training camp were not rated as very influential in terms of causing one to become a fan. Yet such activities may serve to reinforce the team relationship or may simply be a part of the routine of being a team fan without increasing or decreasing attachment to the team, *per se*.

Non-interpersonal factors having the most influence on the sampled fans were related to the linkage between the city and the team. When fans make a linkage between home city

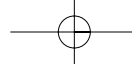
and team, there may be a strong interaction effect that further solidifies the fan/team relationship. In the present case, there is a strong linkage between the team and the city of Cleveland. For many respondents, the Browns are their hometown team. However, respondents did not make citizenship in Cleveland a requirement for being a fan of the team. Therefore, the linkage fans make between city and team needs to be examined from multiple directions to understand its effect on team fans.

Attendance at games was also seen as somewhat influential in furthering team loyalty. There is little question that the excitement of games can help individuals feel excitement about the team and the game itself. The collective behavior of fans toward the favored team may also play an important role in furthering team loyalty.

Implications and Suggestions for Sports Marketers

Sports marketers need to create opportunities for fathers (and, to some extent, mothers) to interact with their children in team-related activities. Fathers clearly play an important role in shaping team choice. As ticket prices increase, it is becoming increasingly more difficult for middle- and lower-income parents to take their children to professional sporting events. Regardless of ticket prices, however, far more fans watch professional sports on television than attend the games. As a result, large numbers of fans are experiencing few direct contacts with their chosen teams.

Sports marketers need to create events where father/child can bond around the team because of the strong and lasting effect such interactions can have on team loyalty. Team fairs, team alumni games and gatherings, where fathers and children can be together and talk about their thoughts and feelings about the team, could serve this purpose. In sum, the linkage between team, father and child is a very powerful tool in shaping team loyalty in an individual.



Creation of a Professional Team Fan

When a link can be made between the city and the team, a potentially powerful source of identification is created. When fans link closely with a city and a team, the synergy of these two concepts should lead to strong and positive feelings about the value of the team to the individual. Sports marketers can use the common characteristics of the team and the city to make the linkage. For example, the blue-collar heritage of Cleveland is frequently linked in ads with the gritty, down-in-the-dirt style of American football played by the Browns. If fans can personally relate to these common city/team themes, then the potential for team loyalty with the team is greatly increased.

The community of team fans can also be used to build a loyal fan base. The presence of others who have the same strong feelings about a sport team supports individual fans to continue in their allegiance with the team, even at a subconscious level. Yet, the nature of this affiliation needs to be understood and utilized by sports marketers very carefully. Our results suggest that respondents valued the presence of team fans around the world, and allowed anyone admission to this fraternity of team faithful. Thus, there is little exclusivity regarding membership in this community. The value of the community of fans concept to an individual is knowing that there are many others who also feel strongly about the team. When sports marketers can ascribe attributes to the fan community that are perceived as positive by potential and existing fans (e.g. die-hard fans, highly loyal), they are providing individuals with an additional reason to remain loyal to the team. By associating with the fan community, individuals can ascribe these attributes to self – a personally enhancing experience. Advertisements directed to the fan community that emphasize the positive/sought attributes of the fan base will help people make a link to the team. These efforts build *esprit de corps* among current fans, while making membership attractive for those considering membership in the fan community.

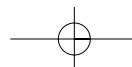
The availability of e-mail and the Internet may be very useful for supporting team fan

loyalty and community. Team-created chat rooms, news groups and other Internet communication vehicles allow fans to interact with other members of the team fan community, without necessarily breaking the anonymity barrier most fans desire. Teams can use these venues as sources for market research data. Team personnel can monitor these messages to identify issues and trends pertinent to fans. Understanding how fans talk and think relative to the team may be very useful in shaping questions used in research studies, media messages, and the delivery of game day services, merchandise, and the like. Operated properly, Internet-related activities could serve as supplements to more costly focus group and small-scale survey research. These Internet forums will serve as a means of ascertaining topics and issues to be addressed in larger studies. Survey studies with statistical sampling methods should also be conducted so that issues of sample selection and representativeness of all fan groups can be fully addressed.

Future Research

One approach to future research is to work with different age groups (preteen, adolescent, and adult) to ascertain the differential influence of various factors on each group. For example, the influence of family members (particularly fathers) and personal experiences should be examined for preteens. The relative importance of friends, social/community issues, and geographic location need to be addressed more deeply as to their importance on an adult's decision to become a team fan. Much more work is needed with adolescents to try to identify more clearly which factors exert an influence on the decision to become a team fan (the importance of family, friends, players and coaches) and the extent to which different factors exert an influence.

The current study also highlights the value of studying the importance of different factors for strengthening and maintaining a team's relationship with their fans. For example, the prevalence of fathers as influence agents may signal that there are emotional bonds that



drive, solidify and reinforce team affiliations. The desire not to disappoint or draw disapproval from one's father could cause some people to become and remain team fans. Fan loyalty may come from the inertia toward a team created by the father. Consideration needs also to be given to the effect of paternal influence on remaining a team fan. Such influence may be important for initial team selection, but other factors may supercede the paternal influence factor as time passes.

A factor that may come to influence adults is team ownership by corporations. For example, in the United States, Disney owns the Anaheim Angels professional baseball team and the Anaheim Mighty Ducks professional hockey team. Similarly, in the UK several media firms, including News Corporation, NTL and Granada, have acquired shares in some of England's biggest Premier League soccer teams.

Corporate ownership of these teams provides the opportunity for high levels of promotion and media exposure that a "privately-owned" team cannot match. In terms of fan loyalty issues, it is possible that organizations that own or sponsor teams may encourage their employees to support the "company team". The impact of such influence on team choice merits further consideration, particularly among adults.

The breadth of issues identified relative to the many influence agents points to the fact that much remains to be known about the factors that drive the team/fan relationship.

In sum, fan loyalty research is a promising line of study that has tremendous potential for helping practitioners and academics better understand the relationship between a team and its fans, as well as how to develop, maintain, and strengthen such relationships. Clearly, we have only begun to scratch the surface of what is likely to be a very complex phenomenon. ●

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